

POLESTAR ADVISORY · SPOT REPORT

Two Civilian Shootings in a Week: How Safe is the Trans-Papua Road?

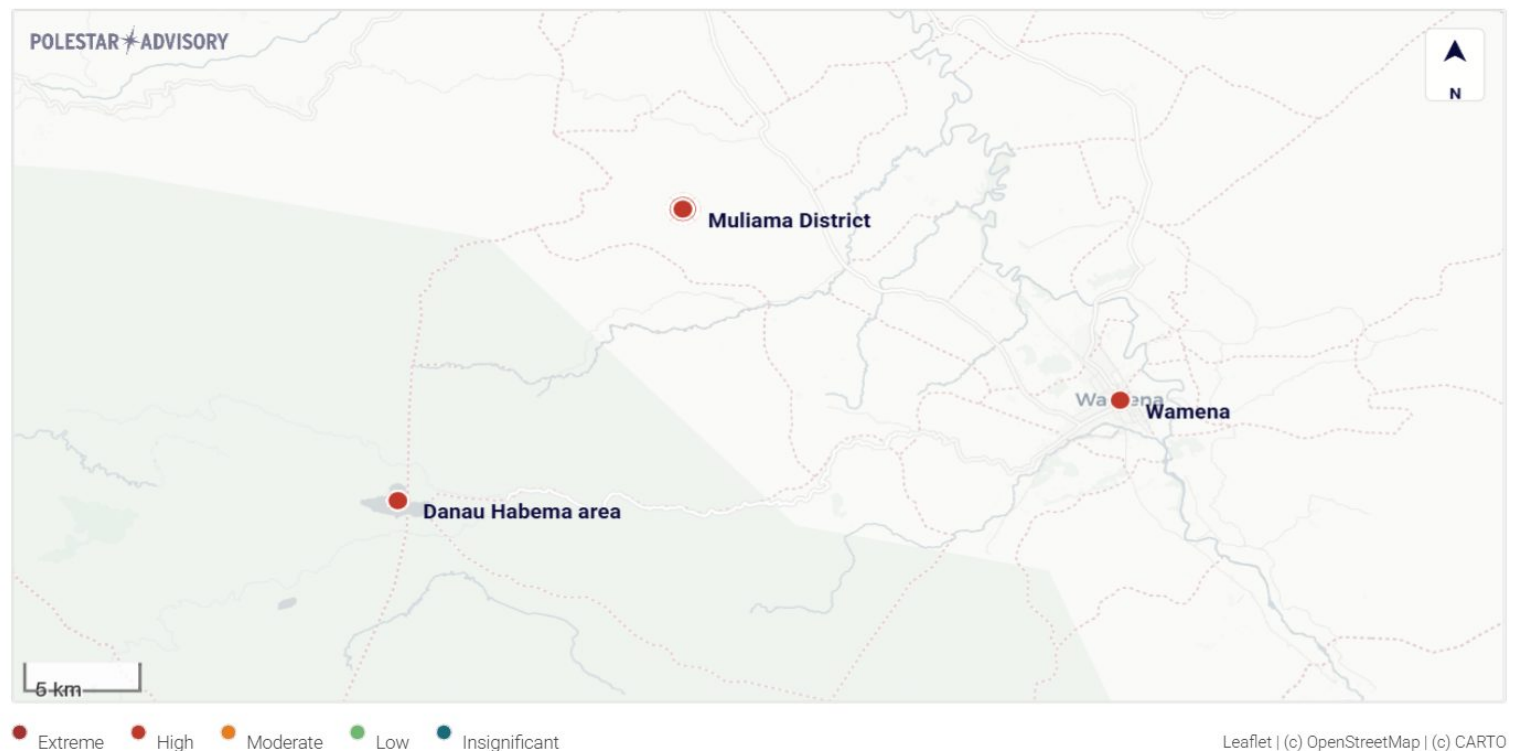
HIGH	LOCATION	REPORT DATE	INCIDENT DATE	CATEGORY
	Papua, Indonesia	16 Sep 2026 20:51	15 Sep 2026 00:00	Crime/Insurgency

BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

Two fatal attacks on civilian road users within seven days indicate a significant deterioration in security on routes radiating from Wamena, particularly towards Nduga/Mbua and the western Jayawijaya highlands. Three government agricultural workers were killed near Muliama on 9 September, followed by the killing of a civilian driver travelling the Wamena–Mbua route on 15 September.

The incidents do not demonstrate that the entire Trans-Papua road network is unsafe. They do, however, show that sections of the central highlands network around Wamena currently present a substantially elevated threat to civilian road movement. This is reinforced by an explicit TPNPB warning directed at civilian drivers, civil servants and migrant residents using several Wamena corridors

LOCATION MAP



INCIDENT DETAILS

On 9 September, an 11-person Jayawijaya Agriculture Office group was returning towards Wamena after work in Muliama District when it was intercepted by an armed group. Police said the attackers separated eight indigenous Papuans, including a child, from three other officials before shooting the three officials. All three died. Investigators recovered 5.56 mm and 9 mm cartridge cases and subsequently identified suspects believed responsible.

Six days later, on 15 September, driver Aris Sanda was travelling from Wamena towards Mbua when his vehicle was stopped near the Danau Habema/Gunung Boy area. He was subsequently found dead with his vehicle burned. TNI's Habema command attributed the attack to OPM/TPNPB Kodap III Ndugama; TPNPB separately claimed responsibility.

TPNPB alleged that the driver was associated with Indonesian military intelligence. That allegation has not been independently substantiated and should not be treated as established fact.

CURRENT SITUATION

The most concerning development is not simply the number of fatalities but the apparent deliberate interception of civilian vehicles.

The 9 September attack involved an official civilian group travelling on routine government business. The 15 September incident involved a commercial driver carrying passengers. Both occurred during daylight hours, indicating that daylight movement alone does not provide meaningful protection against deliberate roadside interception.

TPNPB has subsequently warned migrant residents, motorcycle-taxi and vehicle drivers, and civil servants against movement on the Wamena–Nduga, Wamena–Tolikara, Wamena–Yalimo and Wamena–Jayapura corridors.

OPERATIONAL IMPACT

Commercial, NGO, government and contractor movements outside Wamena now face increased exposure where routes enter sparsely populated highland areas with limited security presence, communications and alternative routing.

Personnel perceived as non-local, government-associated or supporting logistics into contested areas may face greater exposure. The deliberate separation of occupants during the Muliama attack is particularly important for organisations assessing individual traveller profiles rather than simply vehicle or journey risk.

Disruption may also occur without formal road closure as drivers become reluctant to operate particular routes, potentially affecting passenger transport, food movement, project access and last-mile logistics.

POLESTAR VIEW

The Trans-Papua road should not be assessed as one security environment. Conditions around Sorong, Jayapura, Merauke or other sections cannot be inferred from events in the central highlands.

The immediate concern is a Wamena-centred cluster of road-security incidents.

The two attacks show both capability and intent to stop vehicles and select individuals from among civilian travellers. More importantly, the subsequent TPNPB warning expands the threatened geography beyond the individual attack sites.

For organisations operating from Wamena, the question is therefore no longer simply whether the Trans-Papua road is open. It is whether the specific road, traveller profile, destination and current armed-group activity make that journey acceptable.

OUTLOOK (24–72H)

Security-force search activity is likely to increase around the affected corridors following the killing of Aris Sanda and the continuing investigation into the Muliama attack.

Further threats, temporary movement restrictions or disruption to local transport services are possible. The greatest immediate concern remains the Wamena–Mbua/Nduga axis and adjoining western highland routes, rather than the Trans-Papua network nationally.

RECOMMENDED ACTIONS

- Suspend non-essential road travel from Wamena towards Nduga/Mbua pending a fresh local security assessment. Review all planned movement into Muliama and western Jayawijaya individually rather than treating the wider Trans-Papua network as uniformly accessible. Use air movement where operationally viable for higher-exposure destinations. Conduct same-day route and security checks immediately before departure. Avoid solo and untracked movements and maintain positive communications throughout journeys. Review traveller profiles, particularly non-local personnel and staff visibly associated with government, infrastructure or logistics activity. Do not rely on daylight movement as the principal mitigation; both recent attacks occurred during daylight hours.

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